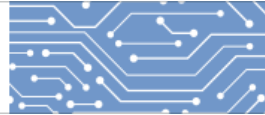


Cisco Systems Inc. (CSCO): Communacopia + Technology 2026 — Key Takeaways

Communacopia + Technology
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Michael Ng, CFA
+1(212)902-8618 | michael.ng@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Yash Goenka, CFA
+1(212)934-6312 |
yash.goenka@gs.com
Goldman Sachs India SPL

Katherine Murphy
+1(212)902-1151 |
katherine.a.murphy@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Lindsey Shema
+1(212)902-6506 |
lindsey.shema@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Presenters: CSCO's Chief Financial Officer, Mark Patterson, and President & Chief Product Officer, Jeetu Patel, presented at the Communacopia + Technology Conference.

Bottom Line: CSCO is well positioned to capitalize on a multi-year, AI-driven networking supercycle, with demand across all customer types and its entire product portfolio. AI demand is driving tailwinds across hyperscale, neocloud, and enterprise, as well as data center switching, routing, security, observability, and campus networking. CSCO reiterated its F2027 revenue outlook, which includes 15% revenue growth at the midpoint with \$7.5 bn of hyperscale AI revenue.

Key Takeaways

- **Agentic AI driving a multi-year networking supercycle:** Management highlighted a secular shift driven by AI agents. Agentic AI is driving a 5x increase in network bandwidth consumption, catalyzing a durable networking demand cycle across all of CSCO's customer segments including hyperscale, neocloud, and enterprise, as well as its product segments. For instance, this includes back-end and front-end networking, security & observability, as well as campus networking, where growth has accelerated from historical 3–4% levels to double-digits. Physical AI likely will drive an additional vector of growth.
- **Reiterated fiscal 2027 guidance driven by core refresh and AI momentum:** CSCO's fiscal 2027 guidance implies 15% total revenue growth at the midpoint, supported by an estimated double-digit ex-AI baseline growth. This acceleration is underpinned by a >\$100 billion end-of-life/end-of-support infrastructure refresh opportunity over the next few years.
- **Hyperscaler AI orders scale rapidly alongside vertical integration strategy:** CSCO secured \$9.3 billion in fiscal 2026 hyperscaler AI orders, an acceleration from nearly zero just two years prior. The company is leveraging a vertically

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integrated, co-designed full stack, deploying scale-out systems powered by the G300 Silicon One chip and scale-across P-Series chips. Management noted that by 2029, CSCO will be completely independent of merchant silicon providers.

- **Navigating near-term margin compression offset by operating leverage while maintaining robust shareholder returns:** CSCO's F1Q27E gross margins guidance of 65%-66% reflects a slight headwind as the company leans into hardware-heavy hyperscale and enterprise AI deployments where revenue is recognized on day one, while attached software and services are recognized ratably. However, management emphasized record operating efficiency, noting that in F4Q26, gross margins declined ~2 points year-over-year, but OpEx margins declined by almost 4 points as a percentage of revenue, driving record operating margins.
- **Fusing security into the network fabric to capture machine-scale defense:** CSCO reiterated F2027 security revenue growth to accelerate to high single-digits yoy, driven by the lapping of Splunk's cloud transition, >30% firewall growth over the past two quarters, and new product customers momentum. The company is leveraging its unique position to integrate Data Processing Units (DPUs) and Neural Processing Units (NPU) directly onto top-of-rack smart switches, significantly reducing latency and embedding security into the network architecture to monitor behavioral drift and secure agentic AI at runtime.
- **Strategic partnerships expanding the Secure AI Factory:** CSCO is simplifying the deployment of on-premises AI workloads through its expanded Secure AI Factory partnership with NVIDIA and Supermicro. By integrating Supermicro's rack-scale compute capabilities, CSCO can deliver full-stack solutions (server, networking, security, observability, and data) with favorable net margin treatment, avoiding the historical margin headwinds of the compute business while driving significant cross-sell potential across its proprietary technologies.

Valuation/Risks

Valuation. We are Neutral-rated on CSCO with a 12-month target price of \$125 based on 25x our NTM+1Y (Q5-Q8) EPS.

Key upside risks include secular tailwinds including hybrid work, multi-cloud network architecture adoption, broader roll-out of WiFi 6/6E and 5G, increasing edge compute use cases; New disaggregated consumption models to target previously underserved cloud providers, near-term revenue visibility from elevated backlog; **downside risks** include competition, including from major Chinese providers Huawei & H3C and White Box solutions; margin degradation from mix shift into more cloud customers, elevated costs associated with supply chain headwinds; broader pricing pressure from commoditization of networking hardware; dilutive acquisitions.

Investment thesis summary. CSCO is the global market share leader of networking equipment and solutions with a comprehensive platform of offerings across networking, security, collaboration, applications, and cloud. As a leading #1 or #2 incumbent in nearly every product type and category it participates in, CSCO has been subject to market share losses over the last decade, particularly due to lower cost competitors

(e.g., White Box) and smaller, more nimble companies with specific vertical solutions (e.g., ANET in data center switching, FFIV in ADC). That said, CSCO has the widest offering of networking solutions among any of its key competitors, cementing its role as a trusted networking solutions provider, as well as a key procurement partner for its suppliers. Product backlog, RPO, and ARR provide ample revenue visibility even if order growth slows in the near term as customers absorb previously placed orders & more closely scrutinize IT budgets in a challenging macro environment.

CSCO	12m Price Target: \$125.00	Price: \$109.20	Upside: 14.5%
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Neutral		GS Forecast				
Market cap: \$435.1bn Enterprise value: \$439.1bn 3m ADTV: \$2.6bn United States Americas Hardware, Media, Cable, Telco M&A Rank: 3			7/26	7/27E	7/28E	7/29E
	Revenue (\$ mn)	63,325.0	72,686.3	78,309.6	84,460.4	
	EBITDA (\$ mn)	24,580.0	28,516.6	30,041.1	32,138.8	
	EBIT (\$ mn)	22,040.0	25,496.5	27,486.8	29,997.7	
	EPS (\$)	4.33	5.06	5.52	6.12	
	P/E (X)	19.7	21.6	19.8	17.9	
	EV/EBITDA (X)	14.3	15.3	14.3	13.0	
	FCF yield (%)	3.8	4.8	5.1	5.5	
	Dividend yield (%)	1.9	1.6	1.6	1.6	
	Net debt/EBITDA (X)	0.6	0.1	(0.2)	(0.6)	
		7/26	10/26E	1/27E	4/27E	
	EPS (\$)	1.22	1.33	1.21	1.22	

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 4 Sep 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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Contributing Authors: Michael Ng, CFA Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Yash Goenka, CFA Goldman Sachs India SPL, Katherine Murphy Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Lindsey Shema Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC.

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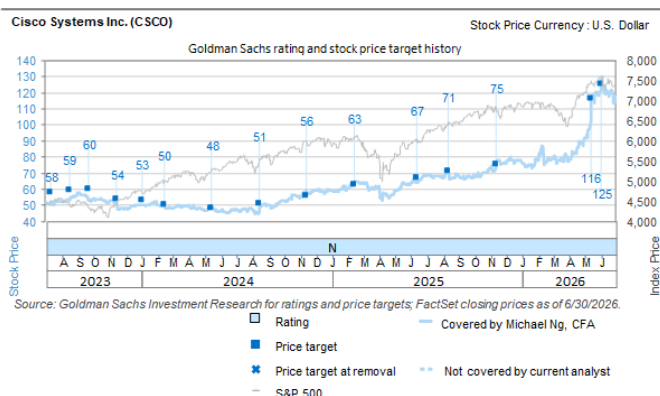
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Cisco Systems Inc. (CSCO)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
03-Jun-26	125.00	126.50
14-May-26	116.00	115.53
13-Nov-25	75.00	77.38
14-Aug-25	71.00	69.30
13-Jun-25	67.00	64.09
13-Feb-25	63.00	63.84
14-Nov-24	56.00	57.92
15-Aug-24	51.00	48.53
16-May-24	48.00	48.34
15-Feb-24	50.00	49.06
02-Jan-24	53.00	50.51
16-Nov-23	54.00	48.04
22-Sep-23	60.00	53.57

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